Sounis: A LiveJournal Reading Community

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ABSTRACT

UPDATED—25 June 2018. LiveJournal blogs are a much-studied area of online community research. The community blogging site has long been a popular format for connecting with others over a diverse range of topics. However, over the last several years, LiveJournal has fallen in popularity, particularly with the rise of sites like Facebook, Tumblr, and Twitter. This paper studies a still active LiveJournal community blog called Sounis, a fan site for a young adult book series. A survey of 43 members provides insights into the demographics, participation levels, on-line versus off-line activities, and motivations of the community. Analysis includes correlation calculations between numerical variables and association rule mining among categorical variables. The results reveal a diverse community where members vary in age, posting frequency, social media use; spend much of their time reading; enjoy visiting the site; would like to extend their relationships off-line; and generally feel a strong sense of community on the LiveJournal blog Sounis.

Author Keywords

Online communities; LiveJournal; Sounis; Megan Whalen Turner; The Queen's Thief, fandom; lurking.

ACM Classification Keywords

H.5.10 Collaborative and social computing

INTRODUCTION

The Queen's Thief is a series of young adult novels by Megan Whalen Turner. The first book, *The Thief*, received The Newbery Honor Book Award after its initial release in 1996. Published by Greenwillow Books, the following four books; *The Queen of Attolia*, *The King of Attolia*, *A Conspiracy of Kings*, and most recently, in 2017, *Thick As Thieves* have been released to critical acclaim. The novels mix adventure, war, political intrigue, and a touch of fantasy in a fictional world similar to ancient Greece. Despite the long time periods between book releases and the hard to define genre, the novels boast a small, but incredibly dedicated fan base.

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Like readers in love with the more well-known books such as Harry Potter, Twilight, The Hunger Games, or Game of Thrones, fans of The Queen's Thief enjoy connecting with each other to share their enthusiasm. This can take the form of formal book clubs, official book release parties, author appearances, or simply two friends sitting down to talk about their favorite characters and plots. More frequently, however, these interactions occur online. Sites like MuggleNet for Harry Potter, bellaandedward.com for Twilight, and Quarter Quell for The Hunger Games offer virtual locations for book aficionados to share news, theories, fan fiction, and more.

The Queen's Thief series has a digital presence on GoodReads, Tumblr, and news can be found on the author's own website or Tumblr account. But the primary location for all things Megan Whalen Turner is Sounis, the LiveJournal blog. Here members post everything from author book signing event announcements to fan art. The following study is an attempt to better understand the small online community that fosters such strong and long-lasting devotion to a single author and her work.

Literature Review

Research of online communities is diverse and multifaceted. Blogging, which the LiveJournal platform supports, is the focus of many works, including a study of the motivations of early "online diary" writers by Nardi, Schiano, and Gumbrecht [9]. How much of themselves users are willing to share with an often unknown and public audience is also discussed by applying identity management metaphors to social relationships in 3D virtual worlds in a paper by Leshed and McLeod [6]. This work additionally addresses the separation or intersections between on-line or off-line experiences, using the phrase "material" rather than "real" world so as not to imply that virtual worlds are not real.

Numerous research papers analyze activity levels of members of online communities. Preece and Shneiderman in 2009 defined successive levels of participation from members of the general user population starting as readers, and potentially evolving to contributors, then to collaborators, and eventually to leaders of the community [12]. Thom-Santelli, Muller, and Millien offer alternative classifications of types of community participants, defining social roles of community-seeker, community-builder, evangelist, publisher, and team-leader [13]. A paper from the Georgia Institute of Technology also examines the evolution of participation in a community, this time focused on those who post to Wikipedia [1]. These and many other works identify a particular type of community member, a

"lurker." Defined in various ways, the term generally refers to anyone who attends but does not actively participate in the community, for example, by reading posts but never commenting, liking, or writing posts of their own. Research focused on lurkers includes a study of the nature and motivations of those who do not post by Nonnecke, Andrews, and Preece [10] as well as a paper defining five reasons for lurking by Preece, Nonnecke, and Andrews [11].

Likely due to its popularity and longevity, LiveJournal has been the focus of many research projects about online communities. Most relevant to this paper are works such as those written by Merry and Simon at the Department of Information Studies at Aberystwyth University, UK, which looks at active versus non-active, or "lurking," members and compares the benefits each receive from their level of participation [8]. Gaudeul and Giannetti from the University of Bologna, Italy analyze reciprocity on LiveJournal, studying the extent to which bloggers read each other's posts and providing useful statistics regarding the demographics of LiveJournal users at the time of publication [3].

Also beneficial to the theme of this paper is research related to online fandom. "Joining the backstage: locality and centrality in an online community," thoroughly analyzes the community surrounding a website dedicated to huge fans of Disney and Disneyland [7]. Here Lutters and Ackerman looks closely at the behaviors, motivations, and trends on the small, special interest community, which in many ways parallels that of Sounis on LiveJournal. Guschwan, in the journal Soccer and Society, discusses the rise of media consumers and producers by focusing on a site dedicated to the adoration of a particular soccer player [5]. Here, too, do fandom members participate in activities both on-line and off-line. Two researchers from the University of South Florida, Greone and Hettinger, study social identity theory as impacted by being a fan of media such as television and books [4].

LiveJournal: A Brief History of Participation

Launched in 1999, LiveJournal is an online blogging and social media platform most popular during the early 2000s. According to FastCompany, the site was "king of the blogging hill" [14] because its "easy-to-use interface and a thriving social community brought blogging to the masses" [14]. The site is free to use, although a premium version with additional features is available for a fee. Every new member receives a journal, a username, and a profile page. Posting a blog entry is easy, and new creators are free to choose from a large variety of templates. The community aspects of the site, which distinguish it from standard blog platforms, include a friends page, which is linked from the profile page and journal, and displays recent posts from friends, similar to the Facebook newsfeed. Additionally, shared, or community journals are not the domain of a single user, and allow posting by any member of the community. Sounis is one such community journal.

At its peak in 2005, LiveJournal had more than 2.5 million active accounts [2]. However, during the last thirteen years, the popularity of other, newer online community sites has far eclipsed the blogging platform. In 2007 a Russian company purchased the site and focused growth in non English-speaking regions, including Russia and Singapore. As of 2012, during a push to revive popularity in the United States, LiveJournal had 30 million monthly visitors and 170 million pageviews [14], which still did not compare to the number of overseas visits. According to The Washington Post, by 2014, LiveJournal ranked as the 150th most popular site on the web, significantly behind WordPress and Tumblr, but ahead of Skype or the popular Chinese network Badoo. In eastern Europe, LiveJournal ranked as the 12th most visited site. Popularity in Russia led to the use of the Russian translation of "LJ," (short for LiveJournal) as a phrase to mean any kind of blogging activity [2].

Although Russian ownership helped the site grow internationally even as US use had fallen off, in 2017, a new user agreement promising to ban any posts about "political convictions" or "political solicitation" prompted many more to leave. Users were driven by fears that the changes were aimed at discriminating against LGBTQ users [15]. Some groups still remained active on the site. Perhaps most famously, Game of Thrones author George R. R. Martin was a frequent poster who drew many adoring fans. But in April 2018, even he left the platform and likely took his followers with him. Today, while the future of LiveJournal is not certain, one small community of book fans still stays active. The readers of The Queen's Thief series frequently visit the once mighty social blogging platform.

SOUNIS ON LIVEJOURNAL

"Eddis, Attolia, Sounis" is the official name of the LiveJournal blog first published in November, 2005 as an online book discussion and fan group page for the novels by Megan Whalen Turner. Members refer to the site simply as "Sounis," the name of one of the fictional city-states featured in the books. Membership is open to all, although a LiveJournal account is required. One moderator presides over the community which, at the time of writing, consists of 777 members, including this author. Megan Whalen Turner, the author of The Queen's Thief series, has been known to post on the site and has said in interviews that she often likes to read what others are posting.

Since its creation in 2005, there have been a total of 2,831 blog posts and 61,678 comments on Sounis. Posts include discussions of the books, news related to the novels, author, publisher, or future publications, images of book related art created by fans, and more. One member organizes an annual gift exchange where participants sign up to mail works of fan art to each other. Periodically, members host "read-a-longs" where volunteers summarize and lead

discussions of sections of each book divided by chapter. Live chats occur sporadically, where Sounis members sign in to a virtual chat room called "The Conspiracy Room." Often these chats take the form of roleplaying, where participants choose a favorite character from the books and participate in the chat as if they were that character. A popular post theme on Sounis is called "While she knits," which refers to author Megan Whalen Turner's statement once that while not working on writing her books she spends time knitting. Sounis members lament the slow pace at which Turner produces her fiction, and to console one another, they create posts containing items to entertain or distract while waiting for the author to come out with the next book. These posts often include recommendations for other books, ideas for fan activities, or discussion prompts.

METHODS

Data was collected via a short, voluntary response survey using Google Forms. A link to the survey was posted on the Sounis LiveJournal blog with an explanation of its purpose. Participants were informed all questions were optional, no identifying information would be gathered, not even their LiveJournal usernames, which might provide ties to information the participant may not wish to share in the survey. It was also clearly stated that no use would be made of the data beyond the purposes of the course. The survey consisted of 18 questions, ten of which were multiple choice, seven of which asked for numeric responses, and the final question allowed for a long text response. Respondents were only permitted to take the survey once. This was enforced by requiring participants to sign in using their personal Google accounts, which Google used to ensure each account was limited to one response, however no information about their Google accounts was collected or stored. Over one week, 43 responses were collected.

Before any data mining could be performed, some cleaning and preprocessing was required. Occasionally, questions expecting a numeric response, such as "On average, how many hours a week do you spend on LiveJournal?" were answered with phrases such as "5 or less" or "half an hour." These responses were changed to the closest logical numeric value, 5 and .5 respectively for the examples mentioned above. Additionally, not every participant answered every question. For certain data analysis techniques, this does not present a problem. But, for calculating correlations or performing association rule mining, null values must be accounted for. Rather than replacing null values with a mean, median, or mode as sometimes is applicable in data mining, following the example of similar studies of LiveJournal communities [8], entire survey responses were removed from the data if any question had not been answered.

Data analysis was performed using R and Weka, two popular open source data mining tools. Summary statistics, such as mean, median, mode, and range for numerical variables were calculated in R Studio. Additionally calculated and analyzed with R, were correlations between numerical values where a correlation coefficient of 1 indicates a strong association and 0 indicates little or no association between the variables. Weka was used to perform the Apriori algorithm for association rule mining. This technique measures and compares two aspects of the variables, support and confidence, to find interesting relationships among them. Support refers to the number of times a particular set of data appears in the whole dataset and confidence is how often a particular rule is valid. Lift is the ratio of confidence to support. If lift is greater than 1, this indicates that the rule found is unlikely to have been a selection based on random chance. Only rules with lift values of greater than 1 were considered.

RESULTS

Data was analyzed with the following research questions in mind.

What are the demographics of Sounis? How do they compare to LiveJournal as a whole?

Initial survey questions asked members basic demographic questions in order to better understand the make-up of the community and compare Sounis to LiveJournal as a whole. Unfortunately, at the time of writing, LiveJournal's statistics on user demographics were unavailable. However, several papers [3, 8] offer both references to data provided by LiveJournal in the early 2010s and provide results from their own research to use as comparisons. On Sounis, respondents varied widely in age, ranging from 14 to 62, with a median of 28, and mean of 31; indicating a skew suggesting members tend to be younger with 62 a possible outlier. This corresponds with the LiveJournal 2012 statistics and survey findings where the majority of participants were between 18 and 34 [8].

One might have expected younger users to be more active on social media, or for older users to be more active on the older platform LiveJournal. But, correlation coefficients of .04 and .16 show no such relationship between age and online community participation regardless of platform. Alternatively, one might have predicted that Sounis members would all be older because the first book came out 22 years ago. Or, a finding of only young readers would make sense because the novels are categorized as young adult fiction. But by subtracting the age respondents remembered first discovering The Queen's Thief series from their current age, 3 users indicated having been following the series for 21 years, and 4 users indicated having discovered the books just this year. The general mix of ages on Sounis suggests a community that offers enjoyment for every age.

Regarding gender, only one participant self-identified as male, while the other 42 identified as female. This is high compared to LiveJournal statistics reporting 59% female members, but surveys taken of a Doctor Who fan group and the LiveJournal_UK community also received high female responses, with only 8.8% of the total respondents

identifying as male [8]. Analysis of bloggers in general found a majority male population, though compositions varied greatly depending on the platform or type of blog [3]. Possible explanations for the gender imbalance on Sounis could be anything from female users being more willing to answer surveys to the subject matter of the group being more appealing to women, however; this is pure speculation. Sounis members additionally reported high levels of education, with 93% having at least some college credit, which also corresponds with general blogging statistics [3].

How active are Sounis members on LiveJournal and other platforms?

Survey respondents reported spending, on average, between 0 and 8 hours per week on LiveJournal, with a median of .25 and mean of .85 hours, indicating lower times are more common. During the one week time frame, there were 17 comments and only two blog posts entered on Sounis, suggesting this community blog is less active than the individual LiveJournal blogs studied by Gaudeur and Giannetti who found means of 25.4 comments and 5.54 entries in a week [3]. However, the subject matter of Sounis as a fan site results in activity levels closely tied to external events such as book releases, and this survey was conducted over a year past the most recent publication. When asked about their total number of posts, 23.3% of respondents reported creating more than 5 blog posts, and 27.9% reported creating between 1 and 5 posts. A further 2.3% indicated never having created a blog post but commenting or participating in other ways. Additionally, 53.5% reported participation in The Conspiracy Room, the chat room associated with Sounis where members periodically hold synchronous online discussions.

When asked about their participation levels on Sounis, 27.9% of respondents indicated they have never created a post or written a comment. This behavior, of joining an online community and reading other's inputs but not producing a visible contribution fills many definitions of the much studied term, lurker [12]. Research by Nonnecke, Andrews, and Preece, who found ranges as wide as 48 to 98% of community members consisting of lurkers [10] indicates that Sounis is not particularly unique in having almost 30% of users not post or comment. Lurker's motivations can range from not feeling a need to post, to wanting to learn more about the group before posting, to disliking the group, or having problems with the software [11].

On Sounis, those who identified as non-posters replied to a later question about their motivations for visiting the site with responses such as; "discussing the books", "finding out about upcoming releases and reading reviews/reactions to the existing books," "Figuring out plot intricacies I might have missed myself." These motivations indicate that lurkers on Sounis do not dislike the community or have trouble with the software, but may simply not feel a need to post. One "lurker" did explain that she had only just discovered Sounis, indicating that she wants to learn more about the community before posting in the future.

Sounis members appear to be active users on other sites. 43.9% indicated visiting other pages on LiveJournal and the estimated number of hours per week spent on social media not including LiveJournal ranged from 5 to 25, with a median of 10 and mean of 9.39. However, there does not appear to be any correlation between increased LiveJournal use and increased use of other social media platforms, with a correlation coefficient of .10. 53.5% of respondents said yes to visiting sites related to The Queen's Thief series other than Sounis. A future follow-up question might analyze what those sites are, with GoodReads, Megan Whalen Turner's personal website, or Tumblr as possibilities.

Do Sounis members participate in off-line fandom activities?

The LiveJournal platform lends itself to members maintaining a complete separation of online and off-line worlds or identities. Members of Sounis have LiveJournal usernames rarely related to their real names, profile pictures tend to be favorite quotes or fan art, and discussion on the site focuses on the books and rarely, if ever, includes any information about personal lives. With many online communities, users choose to establish virtual identities separate from that of the real, or "material," world. For example, SecondLife participants studied by Leshed and McLead create whole avatars who have narratives and experiences entirely online [6]. Some online communities, such as the soccer fan site Core de Roma [5] and Disneyland aficionado page, The Castle [7], are centered around place and thus lend themselves to bridging the on-line versus off-line divide. Sounis has no such connection to any physical location. However, like SecondLife members [6], there is a perhaps, somewhat surprisingly high willingness of Sounis survey participants to share more of their identities offline.

When asked if they had ever participated in a meet up, where arrangements were made online to gather in person such as for a book signing or convention, 4.7% responded that they have done so once, and 16.3% responded that they have done so more than once. A full 73.4% selected that they have not been to a meet up, but do wish to if time and location allowed. As the fan base for The Queen's Thief series is relatively small and the author, Megan Whalen Turner, is not particularly active in giving book talks or holding other events, it may not be surprising that many Sounis members who wish to attend in person fan activities have been unable to so far. Only 4.7% indicated that they have no wish to participate in a meet up, demonstrating that Sounis members are, on the whole, eager to combine on-line and off-line community participation.

What motivates Sounis members to participate?

Association rule mining found several connections that provide insight into Sounis members motivations. For example, respondents who strongly agreed with the statement "Visiting Sounis enhances my enjoyment of the Queen's Thief series" were likely to answer yes when asked if Sounis has a "sense of community." Additionally, respondents who have visited the Sounis chat room were also likely to strongly agree with the statement that Sounis enhances enjoyment of the books. Interestingly, participants who indicated having never made a post or comment were likely to respond in favor of attending an off-line book related event if the timing and location allowed, suggesting their willingness to deviate from an otherwise lurker status if the opportunity arose.

The final survey question asked members to write out what they considered to be their primary motivation for visiting Sounis. While not possible to easily analyze statistically, responses were varied with common themes. Many list book discussions as their primary reason for visiting. As one respondent phrased it, "It's one of my favorite book series, and no one I know has read it, so it's nice to have a platform to hear other people's thoughts and the details they have picked up on that I usually have not." A second response on the discussion theme said, "Discussion! Those books are so full of everything and the community has such good theories and analysis! It helps me understand the books better.

Additionally, members come for news about the books, author, and community. "I can't get enough of MWT [Megan Whalen Turner] stuff, so I'm always checking to see if there's anything new coming up or interesting discussions going on." Others list interacting with the community; "Engaging with like-minded readers" or participating in fandom activities; "Seeing fanart" or "getting details for writing better fanfiction." One respondent sums up the sentiments on motivation well, saying she comes to Sounis because she enjoys "Hearing other people's thoughts/theories especially around the time of new releases. Keeping the love alive during the long hiatuses."

Threats to Validity

Samples gathered by the voluntary participation of respondents are inherently flawed at representing the true population. Often, those who take the time and energy to fill out a survey have different backgrounds, opinions, or characteristics than those who do not. It is possible that the 43 people who answered the Sounis survey about online communities are more interested and possibly more active in online communities. Additionally, the survey was only open for a week, and at a time not near a large Sounis news event, such as a book release. This also makes respondents more likely to be those who are more active on LiveJournal, because less active members may not have signed on during this period, and thus never have seen the survey invitation. These flaws could be reduced in future research by, for example, gathering survey responses for a larger time period, for multiple time periods, or perhaps generating a random sample of all 777 members of Sounis and directly messaging a survey invitation, rather than relying on participants to log in themselves and see the post.

A more difficult flaw to mitigate resulted from the spread of the survey invitation beyond LiveJournal. The survey link was only posted on Sounis, however, one respondent indicated that they had reached the survey through a link posted on Tumblr, a completely different online community. Presumably, some member of Sounis shared the link on this other platform, not considering the implications to the validity of the results. The respondent who answered via Tumblr gave answers indicating she is not a LiveJournal user at all. Therefore, her responses are not informative about the Sounis LiveJournal community and detract from the utility of the study. Her data was easily removed from the results however, it is possible that other respondents also found the survey through other online platforms without making any reference to the fact in their responses. In future research, a question should be included asking where participants found out about the survey, so that non-LiveJournal responses may be ignored.

Conclusion

Analysis of an online community like Sounis provides insights into various aspects of social behavior. Surveying the LiveJournal fan site created an opportunity to compare Sounis to analysis of other online communities, and take note of the various ways this group conforms to and deviates from the existing literature. The blog dedicated to the novels by Megan Whalen Turner is active despite its reliance on a dying platform, has demographics similar to those of LiveJournal at its peak, with members who are eager to participate in fan activities on-line and off, and are motivated to visit the site by the desire for news, discussion, and community. Clearly, Sounis is much beloved by its users, and hopefully members will continue to post, comment, or lurk for years to come.

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